AI Without the Hype

The Starter Playbook

A free companion to the talk "AI Without the Hype: What It Actually Means for Your Business"

Mitchell Community College Small Business Center, October 30, 2026

By Giovanni Rufino

Start here: The one habit

The talk came down to one habit:

Not sure if AI can do it? Ask it.

AI tools change every few months. New features show up and old ones move, so a list of tricks goes out of date fast. The habit of asking keeps working.

This playbook won't teach you every tool. It shows you how to start safely and how to tell AI about your business so its answers fit. Then it gives you prompts you can copy and use today.

You need one thing to get started: A general AI assistant, the kind you chat with in a web browser or phone app. If you already use one, use that one. The free versions handle most of this guide. The top two rungs of the ladder usually need a separate tool.

Here's how the playbook is laid out:

1. The four guardrails: Read these first.
2. Tell AI about your business: A one-page template you fill in once.
3. Find your business model: Five profiles to help you pick a starting point.
4. The ladder: Eight jobs AI can do for you, with prompts for each.
5. Where to get help.

The four guardrails

These are the same four rules from the talk. Every prompt in this playbook assumes you're following them.

1 Know what not to put in

Think of anything you type or upload into an AI tool as something that leaves your building. Some tools store it. Some use it to train future versions. Even when a company promises privacy, you're trusting them with it.

Keep these out:

- Payment card numbers and bank account numbers

- Passwords and login codes
- Social Security numbers and tax ID numbers
- Customer details that identify a person, like a name paired with an address or phone number
- Employee records, such as pay or performance reviews
- Health information about anyone
- Anything covered by a contract or confidentiality agreement
- Trade secrets you'd be upset to see a competitor use, like a recipe or a pricing formula

You can still get help with these tasks. Swap real details for placeholders. When you want help writing a reply, "Customer A" works as well as a real name.

Two more things to check:

- **Your tool's data settings:** Many AI tools let you stop them from using your conversations for training. Look in the settings for words like "data controls" or "improve the model." If you can't find it, search the company's help pages.
- **Your industry's rules:** Some industries, such as health care and finance, have rules about client information. Check yours before you use AI with any client details.

2 Check the sources

AI can state things that sound right and aren't. It can even make up sources that look real.

When AI gives you a fact you plan to rely on, ask: "Where did that come from? Give me a link." Then open the link and make sure it says what AI claims. For tax rules and regulations, go straight to the official source, like the North Carolina General Assembly (https://www.ncleg.gov/) for state laws or the North Carolina Department of Revenue.

3 Verify every response

AI writes the first draft, and you're the editor who decides what goes out the door.

Read every word before it goes to a customer. Check every number yourself. A good rule of thumb: The more it would cost you if the answer were wrong, the more carefully you check it.

4 Limit what it can reach

Some AI tools ask to connect to your email, calendar, files, or bank account. Each connection gives the tool more reach into your business.

Before you click "allow":

- Give it the least access that gets the job done. If it only needs to read, don't let it send or delete.
- Connect only the accounts you need right now. Learn how to disconnect them, and do it when you stop using the tool.

If a tool wants access to everything before it does anything, slow down.

Tell AI about your business

AI gives generic answers when it knows nothing about you. One page of context fixes most of that.

Fill in this template once. Save it in a document on your computer or phone. When you start a new chat, paste it in first, then ask your question.

Some AI tools can save this for you so you don't have to paste it every time. Look in the settings for "custom instructions," "personalization," or "projects." If you can't find it, ask the AI: "How do I save information about my business so you remember it?"

Leave out anything from guardrail 1. This template is about how your business works, not about specific people or accounts.

Business context template

ABOUT MY BUSINESS

Business name:
What we sell or do:
Who our customers are:
Where we work (town, region, or online):
How customers usually find us:
Where we are online, if anywhere (website, social media pages):
How we talk to customers (for example: Friendly and casual, or formal):
Words or phrases we like to use:
Words or phrases we never use:
Our busiest times of day, week, or year:
How many people work here and what they do:
Tools we already use (email, scheduling, bookkeeping, and so on):
What I want help with most right now:
Things you should never do in your answers (for example: Promise discounts, give legal advice, make up prices):

Update it when something changes, like a new service or a new busy season.

Find your business model

Small businesses that look different on the outside often run the same way underneath. A hair salon and an HVAC company both live and die by their schedules. A craft brewery and a machine shop both answer to quality

specs and supplier emails.

Find the profile that sounds most like you. If two fit, read both. Each one suggests which rungs of the ladder to try first, and the next section explains all eight.

Appointment-based services

Examples: Salons and barbers, pet groomers, tutors, HVAC and plumbing service calls, consultants, home cleaning.

Where your time goes: Scheduling and rescheduling, reminders, no-shows, answering the same questions over and over, and missing calls while your hands are busy.

Try first:

> **Writes for you:** Appointment reminders and follow-up messages.
>
> **Plans for you:** Next week's schedule around time-off requests.
>
> **Acts for you:** An AI phone answering service, once missed calls are costing you jobs.

Watch out for: Appointment notes. They often hold personal details that belong under guardrail 1.

Product sellers

Examples: Retail shops, online stores, makers and crafters, food and beverage producers.

Where your time goes: Product descriptions, social media posts, keeping track of stock, customer questions, and returns.

Try first:

> **Writes for you:** Product descriptions and posts.
>
> **Sees for you:** Photograph a product and ask for a description to start from.
>
> **Watches for you:** Alerts for new reviews or low stock.
>
> **Counts for you:** See which products sell and which ones sit on the shelf.

Watch out for: Product claims. If AI writes "all natural" or "made in the USA," you are the one making that claim. Check every one.

Quote-and-project businesses

Examples: Contractors, landscapers, designers and agencies, custom fabrication, event planners.

Where your time goes: Estimates and proposals, change orders, project updates, and chasing payments.

Try first:

> **Writes for you:** Turn your rough notes into a clean proposal.
>
> **Reads for you:** Summarize a long bid request or project spec.
>
> **Plans for you:** Lay out a project schedule.
>
> **Counts for you:** Compare your estimate to what the job actually cost.

Watch out for: The math. Check every number in an estimate before it goes to a client.

Recurring and membership businesses

Examples: Gyms and studios, subscription boxes, cleaning or lawn care on a contract, IT support plans.

Where your time goes: Renewals, cancellations, keeping members coming back, and billing questions.

Try first:

> **Writes for you:** Renewal reminders and "we miss you" messages.
>
> **Watches for you:** Alerts when a renewal is coming up or an account goes past due.

Watch out for: Billing exports. Delete card numbers and account numbers before you upload a report.

Small manufacturers and B2B suppliers

Examples: Machine shops, food processors, parts suppliers, distributors, print shops.

Where your time goes: Requests for quotes, spec sheets, supplier emails, written procedures, training new hires, and quality records.

Try first:

> **Reads for you:** Summarize a quote request or a safety data sheet.

> **Writes for you:** Turn "how we do it" into a written procedure.

> **Translates for you:** Instructions for crew members in their first language.

> **Sees for you:** Photograph a defect and ask AI to describe it for a quality report.

Watch out for: Customer drawings and specs. They are often covered by a confidentiality agreement. Check before you upload, and never upload anything marked export-controlled.

The ladder: Eight jobs AI can do for you

The talk had time for four rungs. This playbook adds four more that fit between them, for eight in all. Each rung asks a little more of you and of the tool.

8	**Acts for you**	An AI that answers your phone
7	**Watches for you**	An alert about a new one-star review
6	**Plans for you**	A schedule around time-off requests
5	**Counts for you**	Last month's expenses, sorted
4	**Sees for you**	A photo of a crushed shipment
3	**Reads for you**	A supplier's proposal before a meeting
2	**Translates for you**	A customer's text in Spanish
1	**Writes for you**	A reply to an upset customer

The lower rungs only need a general AI assistant. The top rungs usually need a separate tool that connects to your accounts, which is why guardrail 4 matters most up there.

Every prompt below works best after you paste in your business context from the template.

1 Writes for you

From the talk

AI writes a first draft, and you edit it and send it. It's the easiest rung to start on.

Example from the talk: A customer email. A customer writes in upset about a late order. AI drafts a calm, clear reply in your voice.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Verify every response. Read every word before it goes out.

Starter prompts:

> Using the information about my business above, write a reply to this customer email. Keep it short and friendly. Don't promise anything I haven't said we can do. Here's their email: **[paste email]**

> Here's a message I wrote. Make it clearer and friendlier without making it longer: **[paste your message]**

2 Translates for you

New in this playbook

AI can turn your message into another language and match the tone you want. Use it when a customer writes in Spanish, or when your crew needs instructions in their first language.

Example: A customer texts you a question in Spanish. AI translates it and helps you write a friendly reply in Spanish.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Verify every response. Ask AI to translate its answer back into English so you can check the meaning. For contracts or safety instructions, have a fluent speaker read it before it goes out.

Starter prompt:

> Translate this message into Spanish for a customer. Keep it friendly and simple, like a local business owner talking to a neighbor. Then translate your version back into English so I can check that it says what I meant. Here's the message: **[paste message]**

3 Reads for you

From the talk

AI can read long documents and pull out what matters. Hand it a long bid request or the packet for tomorrow's meeting, and it can summarize the parts you need.

Example from the talk: Meeting prep. You have a meeting tomorrow with a new supplier. AI reads their proposal and tells you what to ask.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Check the sources. Ask AI to point to where in the document it found each point, then look for yourself.

Starter prompt:

> I have a meeting with **[who]** about **[topic]**. Here's what they sent me: **[paste text or upload the document]**. Give me a one-page summary. Then list the questions I should ask and anything that looks unusual or unfavorable to me. For each point, tell me where in the document you found it.

4 Sees for you

New in this playbook

Most AI tools can look at a photo and tell you what's in it. Snap a picture of a handwritten order, a damaged shipment, an error code on a machine, or a part that doesn't look right, and ask AI about it.

Example: A box arrives crushed. You photograph it and ask AI to describe the damage and draft a claim to the shipper.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Know what not to put in. Photos catch more than you meant to share. Before uploading, check the background for things like a customer's name on a whiteboard or a credit card on the counter.

Starter prompt:

> Here's a photo of **[what it is]**. Describe what you see and tell me anything you're not sure about. Then help me **[what you need: Write a claim, read the numbers, figure out what's wrong]**.

5 Counts for you

From the talk

AI can sort and total routine numbers. Think of the bookkeeping chores you put off, like sorting expenses or spotting duplicate charges.

Example from the talk: Routine bookkeeping. You export last month's expenses and ask AI to sort them into categories and flag anything odd.

> **Guardrails that matter most:** Know what not to put in, and verify every response. Delete account numbers before you upload anything. Check AI's totals against your bookkeeping software, because AI can make math mistakes. For tax questions, ask your accountant, not AI.

Starter prompt:

> Here are last month's business expenses. I removed the account numbers. Sort them into categories like supplies, fuel, rent, and software. Show me the total for each category. Then flag anything that looks like a duplicate charge or doesn't fit. **[paste or upload the list]**

6 Plans for you

New in this playbook

Tell AI what needs to happen by when and what you have to work with, and it can lay out the steps. Staff schedules and holiday promotions are good places to start.

Example: Two employees asked for time off the same week. AI drafts a schedule that covers every shift and shows you where you're short.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Verify every response. AI only knows the limits you give it. If it doesn't know your store closes early on Wednesdays, the plan won't either. Read the dates and hours closely before you share a plan with anyone.

Starter prompt:

> I need to **[goal]** by **[date]**. Here's what I have to work with: **[people, hours, budget]**. Make a week-by-week plan. Then tell me what else you'd need to know to make the plan better.

7 Watches for you

New in this playbook

AI keeps an eye on something and tells you when it changes, and you decide what to do. It can alert you when a new review posts or an invoice goes past due.

Example: A one-star review shows up overnight. You get an alert in the morning with a draft reply waiting for your approval.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Limit what it can reach. Watching means connecting AI to your accounts. Give it permission to look, not to change anything, wherever the tool allows that.

Starter prompt:

> I want to know when **[event]** happens in **[the tool or account]**. What are my options for getting an alert? For each option, tell me what access it needs to my account and whether it can be set to view only.

8 Acts for you

From the talk

AI does things on your behalf, like answering your phone or booking appointments. This takes a separate tool. It's also the rung where a mistake can reach a customer before you see it.

Example from the talk: AI phone answering. When you can't get to the phone, the service picks up and answers common questions. Afterward, it texts you a summary of the call.

> **Guardrail that matters most:** Limit what it can reach. Decide what it may do on its own and what it must hand to you. Before you turn it on for customers, call it yourself several times and try to confuse it.

Starter prompt:

> I run a **[type of business]** and I miss about **[number]** calls a week while I'm working. Would an AI phone answering service help me? What questions should I ask a company before I sign up? What should it never be allowed to do without me?

Ready to look at a phone answering, scheduling, or alert tool? The full playbook covers what to look for in each. See what's in it

---

Where to get help

Your local Small Business Center, run by North Carolina's community colleges, offers free, confidential one-on-one counseling and low-cost seminars for business owners. It's a good first call for questions about your business that go beyond AI. To find yours, search for "Small Business Center" and the name of the community college nearest you.

Your accountant for anything about taxes or your books.

An attorney for contracts and anything you're about to sign.

Want the full playbook?

The full playbook picks up where this one stops. It covers:

- How to check the software you already pay for before you buy anything new
- Eight questions to ask about any AI tool before you sign up
- Nine kinds of AI tools, from phone answering to bookkeeping, and what to look for in each
- How to spot fake AI services and scams, and where to report them
- Real companies for each kind of tool, with no paid placements

It comes as a PDF and an EPUB. **Get the full playbook (https://georufino.gumroad.com/l/playbook)**

About the author

Giovanni Rufino is a software engineer who helps teams learn to use AI well. Before software, he spent ten years leading retail and operations teams. georufino.com (https://georufino.com)

The fine print

This playbook is general information to help you learn. It isn't legal, tax, financial, or other professional advice. AI tools change often, so features and settings may look different by the time you read this. You are responsible for what you share with AI tools and for checking anything they produce before you use it. Mentions of types of tools are not endorsements of any company.

You're welcome to share this free playbook, as long as you share it unchanged and keep my name on it.

My privacy policy is at georufino.com/privacy (https://georufino.com/privacy).

Current as of October 2026.